Muhammad Arslan Iqbal

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Research Fields & Specializations

Experimental Economics and Behavioural Economics
Responsible Leadership; Political Economy; Experimental Methodology; Development Economics

Education

The University of Melbourne *March 2020 – Present*
PhD Economics
Supervisors: Prof. Nisvan Erkal and Dr. Aaron Kamm

The University of Melbourne *March 2018 – Dec 2019*
Master of Economics

University of the Punjab, Pakistan *Sep 2010 – Nov 2012*
Master of Science Economics (Equivalent to Honours)
Distinction: Gold Medallist

Research

Do Campaign Promises Affect Elected Leaders' Behavior? JMP

Abstract: Do campaign promises constrain elected leaders when accountability institutions are weak? Experimental literature on guilt aversion suggests promises create psychological costs of reneging, yet elected officials often break their campaign promises. We investigate this using one-shot laboratory elections in which candidates campaign on binding tax for voters and non-binding promise about their own contributions, before deciding whether to actually contribute to or embezzle from the public fund. We vary whether leaders control taxation, whether they can embezzle, and whether they make contribution promises. Our key finding is that while over 80 percent of candidates promise to contribute at least as much as the tax paid by citizens, more than 60 percent subsequently break their promise, and do so maximally, leaving voter payoffs no better than when contribution promises are absent. Our results do not support guilt aversion among the elected leaders as, despite believing voters trust their promises, their behavior is driven by who they are rather than what voters expect from them. Moreover, making taxation endogenous does not improve promise-keeping or voter outcomes. Finally, removing embezzlement opportunities does not lead to more responsible behavior, it merely constrains the choice set. Interestingly, elected leaders without embezzlement option exploit a greater share of their available power selfishly. Overall, our results show that non-binding campaign promises alone cannot discipline leader behavior.

Does Leader Selection Mechanism Affect Leaders' Behavior?

Abstract: Leaders often face a conflict of interest between self-interest and promoting social welfare. Different leadership selection mechanisms can affect leader behavior by (1) influencing the type of individuals who become leaders and (2) exerting direct behavioral effects through feelings of entitlement, legitimacy, and reciprocity. This study compares the overall effects of three leader selection mechanisms (random appointment, meritocracy, and election) on leaders' behavior, while also isolating the behavioral effects of each mechanism by controlling for the types of individuals selected. Using a laboratory experiment, we implement a novel game in which leaders impose taxes on members and decide whether to contribute to or take from the common fund which allows us to analyze a range of leader behaviors, including embezzlement, tax evasion, and socially responsible behavior. We find that, across all treatments, an overwhelming majority of leaders engage in opportunistic rather than responsible behaviors. The leader selection mechanism does not significantly affect leaders' embezzlement, or socially responsible contribution. However, both meritocracy and election significantly increase tax evasion compared to random appointment, with no observed difference between meritocracy and election. Finally, we find suggestive evidence of both entitlement and legitimacy effects under meritocracy and election, but no support for selection or reciprocity effects.

Experience

Economics Tutor *July 2019 – Present*
University of Melbourne, Australia

- Conduct tutorials for undergraduate and graduate economics courses
- Assess and provide feedback on examinations, assignments, and research projects

Assistant Director (Officer Grade-2) *July 2017 – Nov 2018*
State Bank of Pakistan, Karachi, Pakistan

- Completed comprehensive pre-induction training program covering theoretical foundations and professional banking practices

Economics Lecturer *Feb 2016 – July 2017*
Islamabad Model Postgraduate College, H-8, Islamabad

- Taught undergraduate economics courses and managed student academic affairs

Assistant Director, Urban Development Wing *Apr 2015 – Jan 2016*
Lahore Development Authority, Punjab, Pakistan

- Managed housing development schemes and urban planning initiatives

Economics Lecturer *Oct 2013 – Apr 2015*
University of Sargodha, Mandi Bahauddin Campus

- Delivered undergraduate economics lectures and coordinated student affairs
- Organized and supervised extracurricular academic events

Economics Lecturer *Aug 2013 – Oct 2013*
Concordia Group of Colleges (Beaconhouse School System)

- Pioneered blended learning methodology in Pakistan by developing digital course content, online resources, assessments, and instructional videos

Research Assistant *Aug 2012 – Aug 2013*
University of the Punjab, Pakistan

- Conducted econometric analysis, managed data collection processes, and contributed to academic publications under the supervision of Dr. Muhammad Azmat Hayat

Scholarships and Awards

- Jim Perkins PhD Travelling Scholarship *2025*
  University of Exeter, UK
- Faculty of Business and Economics (FBE) Doctoral Program Scholarship *2020-2025*
  Awarded for PhD Economics program at the University of Melbourne, Australia
  University of Melbourne, Australia
- Endeavour Leadership Program (ELP) Scholarship *2018-2019*
  Awarded for Master of Economics program at the University of Melbourne, Australia
  Australian Government
- Distinction in Professional Training Program *2017*
  State Bank Officers Training Scheme (SBOTS) Cohort 21
  National Institute of Banking and Finance (NIBAF), State Bank of Pakistan, Islamabad, Pakistan
- Distinction medals *2012*
  - University of the Punjab Gold Medal
  - Qazi Muhammad Farid Gold Medal
  - Azam Ali Khan Gold Medal
  - Inayat Ali Watson Silver Medal

  Awarded for Master of Science in Economics program at the University of the Punjab, Pakistan

University of the Punjab, Lahore, Pakistan

- Merit Scholarship *2010-2012*
  Awarded for Master of Science in Economics program at the University of the Punjab, Pakistan
  Sumitomo Corporation, Japan
- Merit Scholarship *2008-2010*
  Awarded for Bachelor of Commerce (IT) program at the University of the Punjab, Pakistan
  Hailey College of Commerce, University of the Punjab, Pakistan
- Gold medal & Cash Prize (PKR 220,000) *2012*
  Awarded for securing 1st position in the Intermediate in Commerce program
  Board of Intermediate and Secondary Education (BISE), Sargodha, Pakistan

Publication

Iqbal, M. A., & Younas, M. Z. (2021). Public knowledge, attitudes, and practices towards COVID-19 in Pakistan: A cross-sectional study. *Children and Youth Services Review*, 120, 105784.

Seminars and Conferences

- Behavioural Business Lab (BBL) Reading Group (Invited) *2025*
  Department of Economics, RMIT University, Australia
- The 18th annual Australia New Zealand Workshop on Experimental Economics (ANZWEE) *2025*
  Macquarie University, Australia
- Annual PostGraduate Research (PGR) Conference *2025*
  Department of Economics, University of Exeter, UK
- PhD Economics Seminar & Internal Seminar *2025*
  Department of Economics, University of Reading, UK
- 7th Meeting on Behavioural and Experimental Economics (BEE) *2025*
  University of Florence, Italy
- Annual PhD Conference *2024*
  Department of Economics, Australian National University Australia.
- The 16th annual Australia New Zealand Workshop on Experimental Economics (ANZWEE) *2023*
  Department of Economics, RMIT University, Australia

Software Skills

Experimental: oTree, ORSEE

Programming & Statistical Analysis: Python, Stata, R, ArcGIS Pro

General: LaTeX, GitHub

References

Academic

Prof. Nisvan Erkal
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Dr. Boon Han Koh
Department of Economics
University of Exeter
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Teaching

Nahid Khan
Department of Economics
University of Melbourne
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Collin Li
Department of Economics
University of Melbourne
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